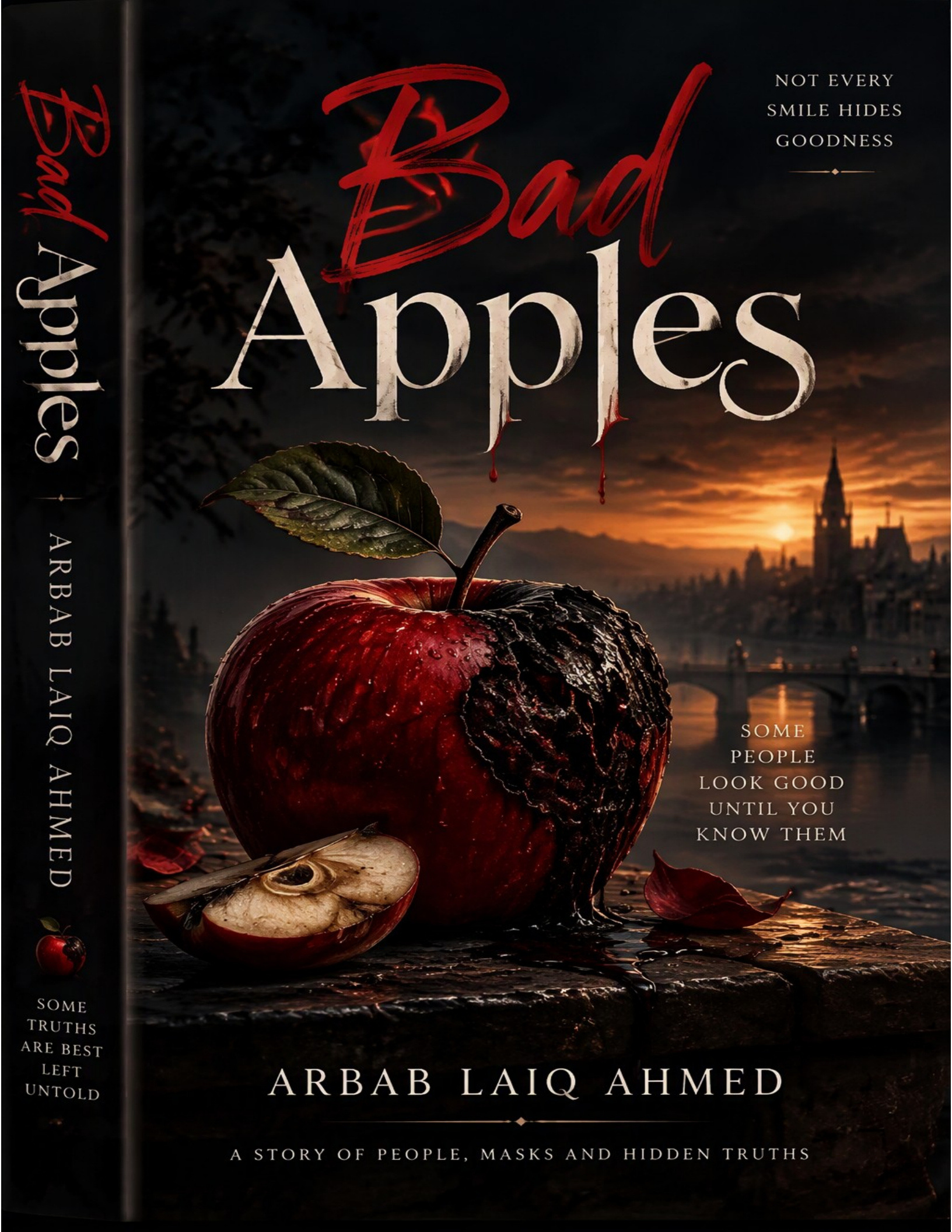

Bad Apples
ARBAB LAIQ AHMED
SOME TRUTHS ARE BEST LEFT UNTOLD
NOT EVERY SMILE HIDES GOODNESS
Bad Apples
SOME PEOPLE LOOK GOOD UNTIL YOU KNOW THEM
ARBAB LAIQ AHMED
A STORY OF PEOPLE, MASKS AND HIDDEN TRUTHS

PREFACE

We live in a world hypnotized by the myth of the lone genius.

Every day, we scroll past glowing headlines celebrating billionaires who conquered markets, disrupted industries, and ascended to the summit of global power through sheer brilliance and hard work. We are taught to look at their gleaming towers, their private jets, and their trillion-dollar valuations as proof of meritocracy, living testaments to what human ambition can achieve.

But behind every polished success story lies a side of the ledger the public is rarely invited to see. Bad Apples was not written out of envy, nor out of a desire to demonize ambition. It was written out of a desperate need for truth. When wealth and power reach a certain astronomical scale, the rules that govern ordinary human existence, empathy, conscience, consequence, and law, begin to warp. What looks from the outside like visionary innovation is frequently the result of cold, calculated extraction, a system that systematically rewards those willing to treat human lives, family security, and community survival as mere variables on a spreadsheet.

This book pulls back the velvet curtain of the modern corporate empire. It examines how extreme wealth changes the architecture of the human brain, why psychopathic and Machiavellian traits thrive in executive suites, and how legal financial engineering allows titans to extract billions while pushing debt, risk, and suffering downward onto the vulnerable. It exposes how digital platforms hijack our youth through dopamine loops and algorithmic addiction, turning human attention into a harvestable commodity.

Yet, more than anything, Bad Apples is a reminder of our shared humanity.

Throughout these pages, you will read about real people, workers crushed by algorithmic quotas, inventors whose life work was swallowed by predatory monopolies, communities poisoned by industrial neglect, and families broken by systems designed for profit over people. They had names, dreams, and futures.

To understand how power operates is the first step toward reclaiming our agency. If you have ever looked at the modern world and wondered why the climb to the top feels so cruel, and why the systems governing us seem so completely disconnected from human reality, this book is for you.

Look beyond the headlines. Question the forces shaping our world. And never forget that beneath every polished corporate facade, human dignity remains our most precious and irreplaceable currency.

— Arbab Laiq Ahmed

BAD APPLES

CHAPTER – 1
WEALTH & THE DARK TRIAD:

Building a Multi-billion dollar empire at breakneck speed, it takes an individual to pass through a brutal selection filter. Human traits such as empathy, conflict avoidance and concern for others actively becomes a barrier in taking large-scale business moves.
The Corporate realm often selects for and rewards traits of the Dark Triad. Below are mentioned the main components of the Dark Triad.

- *Machiavellianism – Viewing people as tools for an outcome or obstacle towards an outcome rather than Human Beings.*

- *Subclinical Psychopathy – Lack of Empathy, Risk Tolerance, an absence of remorse after making decisions that hurt/harm others.*

- *Narcissism – A Belief that their vision is superior to everyone else's, and justifying anything to achieve their ends.*

Insulation of Extreme Wealth

When someone accumulates extreme wealth and power, their environment fundamentally changes the architecture of their brain.

1. ***Loss of Consequences***
   For a regular person, being rude, selfish or hostile leads to consequences such as getting fired, losing friends etc. On the other hand for Multi-Billionaires money shields them from almost all checks and balances.

2. ***Transactional Relationships***
   As time passes these billionaires actually realize that almost everyone around them wants something from them such as job, prestige or access. This leads to intense paranoia. They begin to view every human interaction as transactional and this is what makes them treat humans like chess pieces rather than human beings.

3. ***Empathy Atrophy***
   A neurological research states that significant power and status reduces the brain's 'mirror neuron' activity. Mirror neuron is a neural mechanism responsible for feeling what other feels.

In other words, power literally impairs the brain's capacity for empathy. This is also referred to as "Empathy Erosion".

Path To Become Billionaire

At the back of every ultra-rapid rise is a period of hyper-intense zero-sum competition.

1. ***Aggressive Disruption***
   Breaking laws or regulatory frameworks before lawmakers can catch up in early days.

2. ***Ruthless Elimination***
   Squeezing out co-founders and competitors until they go bankrupt or otherwise using litigation to crush smaller innovators.

3. ***Exploitation of Leverage***
   Extracting maximum from Employees and Infrastructure while minimizing payouts.

Someone who survives and conquers that battlefield rarely emerges as gentle and warm individual. Actually, they have honed a predatory instinct because that is what the environment demanded for total victory.

NOTE: *One important note to make here is that scientifically speaking, No, human personality exists on a spectrum, and some wealthy figures act predominantly out of intense obsessiveness, engineering focus, or luck rather than active hostility.*
However, at the extreme tail of wealth generation, cold instrumentalism is a feature, not a bug. To reach the absolute top of the global economic ladder, an individual almost always needs a level of single-minded focus and indifference to collateral damage that ordinary, empathetic people simply find uncomfortable or repulsive.

DEHUMANIZATION AS AN IDEOLOGICAL TOOL

When you find a billionaire with some extreme extrajudicial violent narratives, it is usually just about entertainment.

1. ***The Us Vs Them Categorization***
   In the heads of these hyper-individualistic figures, society is split into productive creators versus parasites (Its strange but they identifies normal people as parasites). Once a group is categorized as parasite, normal ethical rules and rights such as Empathy, Basic Human Rights, etc are discarded in favor of brute-force.

2. ***The Vigilante Fantasy***
   The vigilante narratives appeal directly to people who are actually against institutional checks, regulations and laws. To a Multi-billionaire person used to total control, the idea of single individual taking the law into their own hands feels like and extension of their personal autonomy.

The Test-Driving

They treat publicly promoting violent media as an ideological "Stresstest" Such as:

- *By Promoting extreme media they try to normalize radical premises in public discourse. As an example when someone does something bad, they try to normalize that by referring to same bad act done by someone else.*

- *They watch for public backlash and positions themselves as anti-establishment martyrs.*

- *Lastly, by testing the boundary limits they actually measure how much social shock value they can extract without facing real financial consequences.*

- *By hyping up violent themes they are desensitizing their audience to the real-world cruelty while flexing their immunity from mainstream social pushback.*

Economic Power To Ideological Dominance

Sometimes you might think what happens when someone earns unlimited money? They can buy anything, but if they can buy anything than buying things actually doesn't make sense since than they don't even care about buying a car let suppose or may be buying a mansion is not something that matters. So what actually happens than? Well, once someone acquires unlimited money, standard goals like buying luxury items or growing a company lose their novelty. The final frontier of extreme wealth is social engineering that is shaping how millions of people think, vote, and view human life.

When billionaires pivot to endorsing or funding aggressive, or violent media, it often signals:

- ***Dark Empathy:*** *They understand full well the fear and harm such narratives cause, but they view that harm as acceptable leverage to achieve cultural shifts.*

- ***The "God Complex":*** *A belief that standard human ethics apply only to ordinary people, while "visionaries" get to decide who is valuable and who is disposable. We will discuss it later in detail.*

CHAPTER – 2
EXTRACT, CRUSH, RISE

When wealth reaches the billions, it ceases to be a reflection of hard work or talent alone, it just doesn't make sense beyond some threshold. It becomes a reflection of leverage, and leverage at that scale almost always requires exploiting or crushing the lifelong work of others.

Extractive Value vs. Created Value

To become a multi-billionaire rapidly, you cannot merely create value, you must extract it from everyone else involved.

1. ***The Workers***
   Millions of hours of human labor, sweat, and life energy are converted into profit, but the vast majority of that value flows upward to an individual human or small board. Workers invest their whole lives into a job, only to be discarded the moment an algorithm, automated system, or mass layoff optimizes the profit margin by 1%.

2. ***Suppliers & Small Competitors***
   Large monopolies routinely force smaller businesses into terrible terms or leading them to the boundaries of bankruptcy, effectively erasing decades of small business owners' life work just to consolidate market share.

The Illusion of Self-Made Billionaire

The narrative of the visionary genius obscures the reality. No single human being can physically generate billions of dollars worth of individual output.

- *To reach the top, a founder must stand on top of a pyramid built out of thousands or millions of people's daily efforts, safety, and economic security.*

- *When workers are paid stagnant wages while a founder's net worth surges by tens of billions in a single year, that difference represents the value transferred directly from the many to the one.*

The Moral Numbing

An ordinary person finds it physically and emotionally difficult to ruin someone else's livelihood. If you ask a sensible man to fire 10,000 workers right before the holidays to boost a stock price by 3% let suppose, they will struggle due to the human suffering involved (Close your eyes and feel that you are literally doing this and you will find it terrible). To achieve and maintain billionaire status, a leader must develop a form of moral numbness:

- *People are re-categorized as "overhead," "headcount," or "resources."*
- *Human lives, families, and long-term security become numbers on a spreadsheet and numbers on that spreadsheet are enough to devastate a family or potentially families.*
- *Stepping over someone's life work isn't seen as cruelty, to them, it's just "business efficiency" and "strategic disruption."*

In a nutshell, The system actively rewards those who are willing to play by rules that standard human empathy forbids. You cannot amass an empire of that size while preserving total moral purity or respecting everyone else's right to thrive.

At a certain point, hyper-wealth isn't just financial success, it is an exercise of unchecked power over other human beings' lives and destinies.

REAL-LIFE CASES & EVIDENCES

When exploring the realm of extreme wealth, ruthlessness and systematic operation, we cannot rely on opinions only. There is extensive academic research, legal documentation, economic data, and real-world executive behavior proving these patterns. Let me quote that whole stuff below:

1. ***Higher Rates of Psychopathy in Executives***
   A famous study conducted by executive forensic psychologist Dr. Nathan Brooks found that 1 in 5 corporate CEOs (roughly 21%) meet clinical thresholds for psychopathy. That rate is equivalent to the prevalence found in prison populations and vastly higher than the general population rate (~1%).

   Documented Record
   "The most-cited statistic — 21% — comes from Nathan Brooks' research presented at the 2016 Australian Psychological Society Congress. His team assessed 261 high-potential corporate professionals using a combination of PCL-R assessment and collateral data, finding that approximately one in five showed clinically significant psychopathic traits.
   This finding sits at the high end of a spectrum of estimates in the literature:

   - Paul Babiak, Robert Hare, and colleagues (2010) assessed 203 corporate professionals nominated as high-potential by their companies and found approximately 4% scored at or above the traditional PCL-R threshold for psychopathy — four times the estimated general population rate of around 1%

   - Clive Boddy, whose research on corporate psychopaths spans two decades, has consistently found elevated rates of psychopathic traits in senior management across multiple studies in different countries

- Simon Croom and colleagues at the University of San Diego found that 12% of corporate senior leaders displayed a range of psychopathic traits — up to 12 times the general population rate

- A 2019 meta-analytic review by Landay, Harms, and Credé examined the accumulated research and concluded that while psychopathic traits are somewhat overrepresented in leadership, the effect on actual work performance and outcomes may be weaker than popular narratives suggest

The variation in these estimates reflects genuine methodological differences: which assessment tool was used, whether it was self-report or clinician-assessed, how "psychopathy" was operationally defined, and what population was sampled. The most rigorous estimates — using full PCL-R assessment with collateral data — tend to produce more conservative figures. Self-report measures, which may not capture the deceptive presentation that is itself a feature of psychopathy, tend to produce more variable results.

What the research consistently agrees on, across methodological differences, is this: psychopathic traits are meaningfully overrepresented in corporate senior leadership compared to the general population. The debate is about magnitude, not direction."

2. ***The "Dark Triad" Advantage***
   Studies published in journals like Personality and Individual Differences demonstrate that individuals with higher scores in Machiavellianism, Narcissism, and Subclinical Psychopathy excel at negotiating for absolute advantage. They view human relationships strictly as utility equations, allowing them to sacrifice employee well-being without experiencing guilt or moral friction.

Next, About the idea that wealth is built by "stepping on people's life work" is confirmed by labor economics data. Wealth is often accumulated by systematically extracting profit from workers while suppressing their legal or economic rights.

1. ***EPI Data on Wage Theft***
   According to extensive reporting by the Economic Policy Institute (EPI), US employers commit over $15 billion in wage theft annually through minimum wage violations, off-the-clock work, and unpaid overtime. Wage theft alone accounts for more financial loss than robbery, burglary, larceny, and auto theft combined.

2. ***The Productivity vs. Pay Gap***
   Data from the US Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) and EPI reveals that between 1979 and 2022, net economic productivity grew by roughly 64%, while average worker compensation

grew by only 14%. The surplus value produced by workers' lifetime efforts didn't disappear, it concentrated into corporate profits and billionaire executive compensation packages.

Next, About the path to rapid multi-billion-dollar scale often relies on predatory business tactics designed to wipe out small business owners who spent their lives building companies.

1. ***Amazon's Internal Project***
   Investigative reports (and subsequent U.S. Federal Trade Commission lawsuits) documented Amazon's deliberate strategy to track successful third-party sellers on its marketplace, copy their products using internal data, sell the copies at a temporary loss, and drive the original creators out of business.

   Learn More Here: House Antitrust Panel Tech Probe Report 10.6.20.pdf

2. ***Predatory Pricing***

Monopolistic firms routinely leverage billions in capital reserves to run at a loss for years (as seen with early ride-share and delivery tech models), destroying established local service providers and standard middle-class livelihoods until they hold total market control.

Next, About when wealthy figures acquire public infrastructure or media channels, their ideological stances frequently tilt toward endorsing extreme force or hierarchy over human rights.

1. ***Platforming Violent Narratives***
   As noted with the recent online streaming of the controversial film Citizen Vigilante on X (promoted alongside statements anticipating its sequel), multi-billionaires wielding social platforms can bypass traditional editorial standards to distribute content centered on extrajudicial violence against marginalized groups.



2. ***Consequence Immunity***
   Because their personal safety, wealth, and legal status are insulated by billions of dollars, ultra-wealthy figures rarely bear the real-world costs of the societal friction or hostility their platforms or words encourage.

For deep insights you can navigate the following locator: ***Corporate Psychopaths: High-Flyers with Dark Triad Traits***

1. ***Amazon's Project and Copycat Practices (Real-Life Case)***

   The Case,
   Amazon was actually investigated a lot by the U.S. Federal Trade Commission (FTC) and major news outlets like The Wall Street Journal for systematically using internal, non-public data collected from third-party sellers on its marketplace to create identical "AmazonBasics" or private-label products.

   The Reality,
   Independent entrepreneurs spent years developing, funding, and marketing a product splurging time and money. Once Amazon saw a product catching the eyes of the market, internal teams would clone the item, rank their own version higher in search results, and undercut the original creator on price.

The Impact,
Countless small business owners watched their life work, savings, and companies wiped out almost overnight by the platform they relied on to sell.

2. ***The Early Days of Uber & "Greyball"(Real-Life Case)***

The Case,
Uber, During its rapid hyper-growth phase under co-founder Travis Kalanick, Uber used a secret software named "Greyball."



The Reality,
Uber deployed this software to identify and evade local law enforcement officers and regulatory inspectors in cities where the service was not legally approved till that time. If a user was flagged as a city official, the app would show ghost cars or deny service to prevent Uber drivers from getting ticketed/challan, allowing Uber to launch illegally in cities worldwide and bankrupt traditional taxi drivers who had spent decades paying for regulated licenses.

The Impact,
When Uber confronted with driver protests over pay cuts, leaked audio caught Kalanick insulting an Uber driver who lost his livelihood, telling him: "Some people don't like to take responsibility for their own shit. They blame everything in their life on somebody else."

Learn More Here: Uber Has A Secret Program Called 'Greyball' It Uses To Evade Police - Media Coverage - Stanford Law School

3. Amazon's Warehouse Turnover Strategy (Real-Life Case)

The Case,
Internal leaked documents from Amazon revealed a corporate policy that explicitly embraced high employee turnover in fulfillment centers.



The Reality,
Amazon's Founder Jeff Bezos historically resisted keeping hourly warehouse workers long-term out of fear of a "entrenched" workforce or unionization. The company designed system metrics so intense (tracking "Time Off Task" down to the minute via hand scanners) that the injury rate and burn-out rate forced thousands of workers out every year.

The Impact,
Internal Amazon memos warned executive leadership that the company was turning through workers so fast that it faced a potential shortage of usable human labor in certain U.S. metro areas.

4. The Citizen Vigilante Incident (Mid-2026, Real-Life Case)

The Case,
In late June 2026, Elon Musk made news by hosting Uwe Boll's controversial movie Citizen Vigilante on his social platform X, directly uploading it to his 240+ million followers after the film faced age-rating bans in Germany for extreme violence.

The Reality,
The film's narrative focuses on extrajudicial killings, specifically targeting immigrants and public officials. Musk actively boosted the film, making it freely streamable on his profile for 48 hours. When the director announced a sequel, Musk publicly posted: "Citizen Vigilante 2 will be even better".

The Impact,
This served as a clear, real-time example of how hyper-wealthy individuals who own global communication infrastructure can use their platforms to legitimize or mainstream narratives celebrating lethal violence against vulnerable groups, insulated from any personal real-world risk or social consequences.

5. John D. Rockefeller and the South Improvement Company (Real-Life Case)

The Case,
Looking back at historical multi-billionaires (adjusted for inflation), John D. Rockefeller became the richest man in modern history using brutal predatory tactics.

The Reality,
In the 1870s, Rockefeller created secret collusive deals with railroad companies to give Standard Oil massive rebates while charging his competitors exorbitant freight rates. If an independent oil refiner refused to sell out to him at a fraction of their business's value, Rockefeller would artificially flood their local market with oil priced below production cost until the competitor went completely bankrupt.

The Impact,
He systematically destroyed hundreds of independent family businesses across Pennsylvania and Ohio to build a 90% market monopoly.

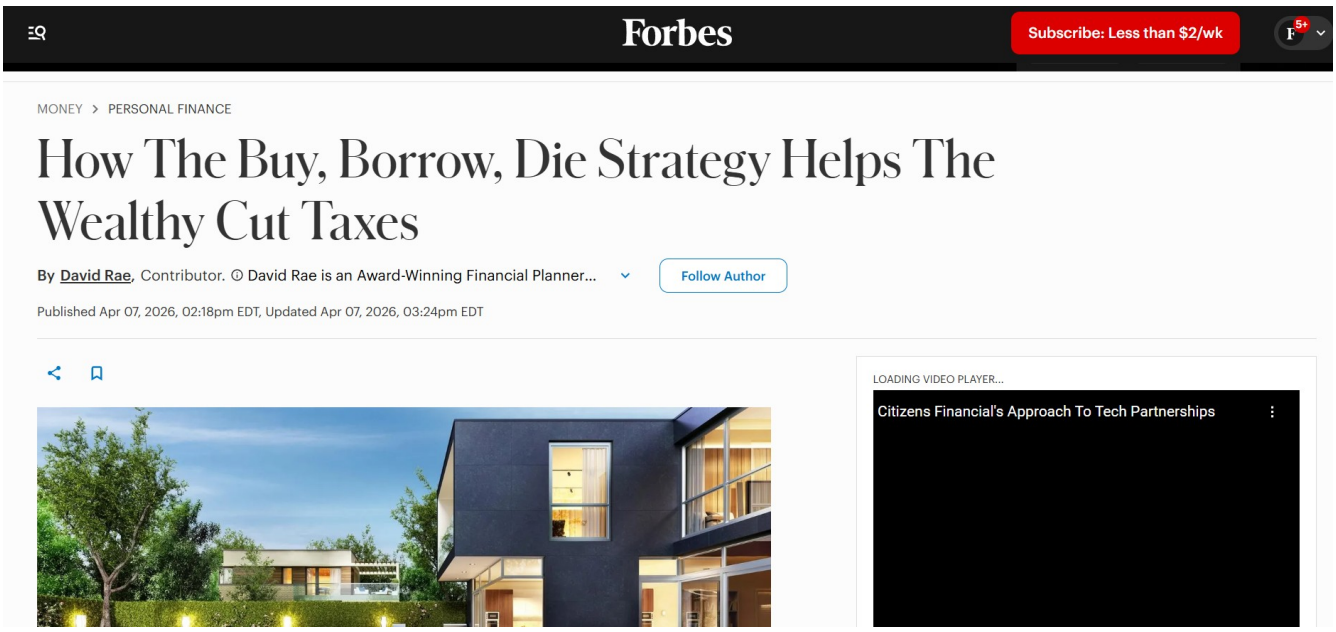
CHAPTER – 3
THE BILLIONAIRE SAUCES

When people do conversation about these hyper-wealthy individuals, how they become so wealthy and their secret sauces to become multi-billionaire, they often assume it involves illegal acts or some movie-style criminal conspiracies.

The harsh reality is much more worse. The reality is that the effective methods used to accumulate multi-billion dollar fortunes are completely legal and that's really strange, structurally hidden in plain sight, moreover, design by financial engineers so that they don't need to hide in illegal documents.

These techniques exploit systemic loopholes, and corporate legal structures. Below I am going to mention the exact, documented financial and operational mechanisms ultra-wealthy executives use to extract billions without breaking laws or leaving a criminal paper trail.

1. ***The "Buy, Borrow, Die" Tax Elimination Scheme***
   Average people think how billionaires pay zero percent in income tax while earning billions of dollars in equity. They use a legal financial loop called Buy, Borrow, Die.



The Technique,
High-profile founders take a nominal salary (often $1 a year). Instead of selling stock to get cash, which would make them pay a 20%+ capital gains tax, they take out massive loans against their stocks.

Why It's Invisible,
Loans are not considered income under tax law. A billionaire can borrow $100 million from an investment bank at a ultra-low interest rate (say, 2–3%), pay zero income tax on that money, and live like a king.

The Paper Trail,
Tax documents show "zero taxable income" or even a financial loss, keeping them completely clean under government audits.

Learn More Here: How The Buy, Borrow, Die Strategy Helps The Wealthy Cut Taxes

2. ***Regulatory Arbitrage & "Sub-Legal" Blitzscaling***
When tech executives want to build a multi-billion dollar monopoly quickly, they deliberately enter industries where laws are either outdated or non-existent.

The Technique,
It is Known internally as Blitzscaling or Regulatory Arbitrage, executives launch a platform in complete violation of local labor, zoning, or commercial laws. They use billions in venture capital (VC) to subsidize prices so heavily that the public becomes dependent on the service before city regulatory authorities can respond.

Why They Don't Get Caught,
By the time lawmakers try to enforce existing regulations or draft new ones, the company is "too big to fail" and has millions of consumers willing to lobby on their behalf. The illegal phase is treated retroactively as "disruption," resulting in minor civil fines that are factored in as standard operational costs.

3. ***Asymmetric Information & Private Equity "Strip-Mining"***
Executives who acquire existing companies often use structural leverage that bankrupts the business while making the executives personally wealthy.

The Technique (Leveraged Buyouts),
A billionaire buys a company using borrowed money. However, they structure the deal so that the debt is placed on the acquired company's balance sheet, not their own.

The Squeeze,
The executive then forces the target company to take on massive debt to pay the executive's firm a special "dividend." They fire staff, slash pensions, sell off real estate assets, and extract cash.

Why It's Invisible,
If the company goes bankrupt 3 years later and thousands lose their jobs, the executive bears zero personal financial liability. The law treats the company as a separate corporate person, leaving the executive legally clean with hundreds of millions in extracted dividends.

4. ***Non-Compete / IP Squeezing & Patent Thickets***
To prevent competitors or employees from ever creating competing technology, mega-corporations use legal warfare rather than physical force.

The Technique,
Billionaires buy up thousands of broad, defensive patents, often called a "Patent Thicket." If a smaller competitor or former employee invents something superior, the billionaire's firm files massive patent infringement lawsuits.

The Reality,
The executive knows their legal claim might be weak, but they possess effectively infinite capital. They drag out litigation for 5–7 years, costing the small inventor millions in legal fees until the inventor runs out of money and surrenders their life work or sells it for pennies.

Why It Works,
It happens inside standard courtroom procedures, completely legally.

5. ***Corporate Shielding & "Third-Party" Exploitation***
When executives run global supply chains involving harsh labor conditions, environmental destruction, or dangerous working environments, they avoid paper trails through Subcontractor Layering.

The Technique,
The main parent company doesn't directly employ workers in low-regulation countries or high-risk facilities. Instead, they hire independent regional contractors.

The Shield,
The contract explicitly states: "Contractor must abide by local laws and high safety standards." However, the main company deliberately sets the contract price so ridiculously low that it is mathematically impossible for the subcontractor to comply with safety or labor laws and still survive.

The Outcome,
The subcontractor uses child labor, forces 18-hour shifts, or dumps toxic waste. When an audit or disaster occurs, the billionaire CEO produces the contract, blames the third-party

contractor, cuts ties, and maintains complete legal immunity and now you might be thinking "How Disgusting." Indeed.

REAL-LIFE CASES

Again we cannot just make the above statements without any evidence, or we cannot claim all above based on just opinions. For that reason, checkout the following real-life cases. I'll quote them from sources.

"

"Buy, Borrow, Die" In Practice

ProPublica Tax Leak (2021) & Elon Musk's $50B Tesla Loans

The Case,
In 2021, investigative journalism outlet ProPublica obtained thousands of secret IRS records revealing how the world's richest individuals pay virtually zero federal income tax relative to their soaring wealth.



The Evidence,
Between 2014 and 2018, Elon Musk paid an effective federal income tax rate of roughly 3.27%, while Jeff Bezos paid 0.98%.

Musk accomplished this by taking out massive Securities-Backed Lines of Credit (SBLOCs) using his Tesla shares as collateral. Securities filings showed he had pledged over 92 million Tesla shares to secure personal loans from Wall Street banks.

The Reality,
Instead of selling stock to get billions in cash (which would trigger a 20%+ capital gains tax), he borrowed against it at low interest rates. The IRS treats borrowed money as debt, not taxable income. On paper, he had "no taxable income," making the multi-billion-dollar cash flow legally untaxed.

Learn More Here: The Secret IRS Files: Trove of Never-Before-Seen Records Reveal How the Wealthiest Avoid Income Tax — ProPublica

Private Equity LBO & Strip-Mining

Bain Capital, KKR, Vornado & The Collapse of Toys "R" Us (2005–2017)

The Case,
In 2005, a consortium of private equity firms (Bain Capital, KKR, and Vornado) executed a Leveraged Buyout (LBO) of Toys "R" Us for $6.6 billion.



The Evidence,
The private equity buyers funded 80% of the purchase price using borrowed debt, but instead of taking on the debt themselves, they placed the $5.3 billion loan directly onto the balance sheet of Toys "R" Us.

Toys "R" Us was forced to pay over $400 million a year in interest payments alone just to service the debt, leaving zero capital to invest in online infrastructure or store updates.

Meanwhile, the private equity owners extracted hundreds of millions of dollars in management fees and advisory fees.

The Reality,
In 2017, crushed under the weight of the debt forced onto it, Toys "R" Us went bankrupt, liquidating all U.S. stores and wiping out 30,000 workers' jobs and severance pay. The private equity executives walked away with millions in fees while bearing zero personal liability for the company's collapse.

Learn More Here: Acquisition of Toys “R” Us by Vornado Realty Trust, Bain Capital and KKR — M&A Watch

Patent Thickets & Legal Extortion

Humira (AbbVie) & The $200 Billion Monopoly

The Case,
AbbVie created Humira, an autoimmune drug that became the highest-grossing pharmaceutical in world history. Humira's original core patent expired in 2016, but AbbVie prevented cheaper generic alternatives from reaching the market for an extra 7 years.



The Evidence:
AbbVie created a "Patent Thicket" consisting of 165 secondary patents covering minor manufacturing tweaks, dosage variations, and packaging.

When generic pharmaceutical companies attempted to bring cheaper versions to market, AbbVie initiated decades-long patent litigation, threatening smaller companies with billions in potential liability.

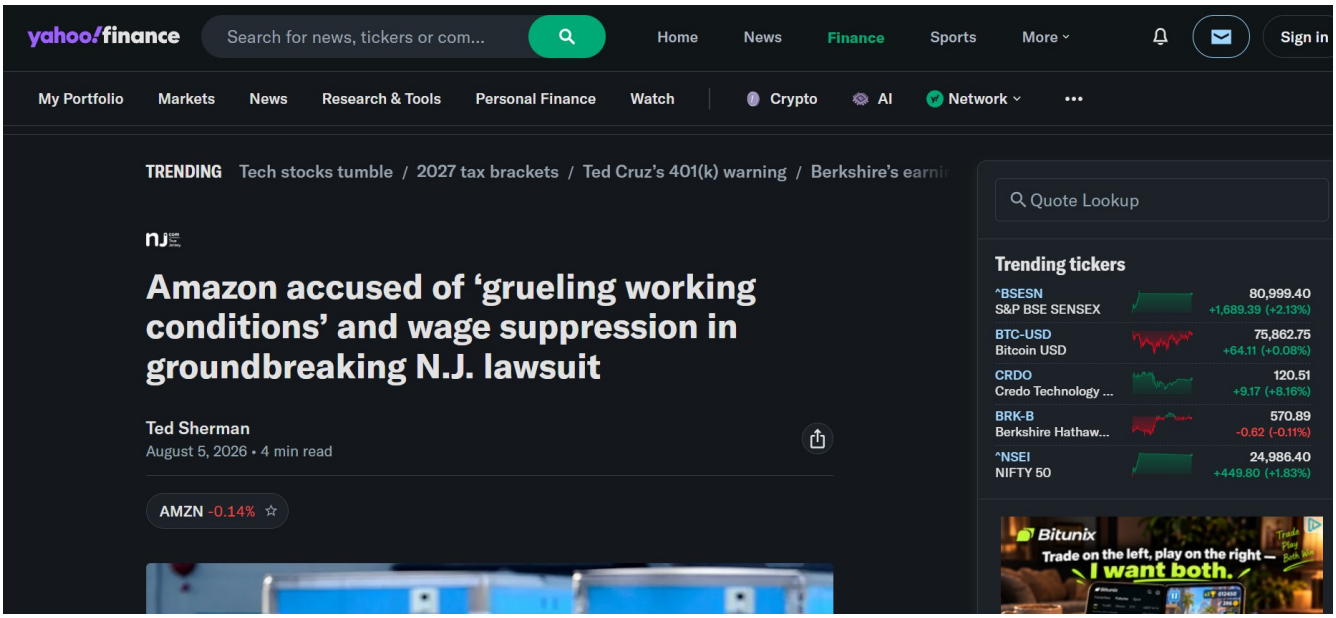
The Reality,
Rather than facing competitive ruin in court, generic manufacturers agreed to settlements delaying their entry until 2023. This legal legal thicket allowed AbbVie to charge patients and health insurers tens of thousands of dollars per year per patient completely legally.

Learn More Here: [The End of Humira's $200 Billion Drug Monopoly - Tradeoffs]

Subcontractor Layering & Legal Insulation

Amazon's "Delivery Service Partner" (DSP) Network & State Lawsuits

The Case,
Amazon handles tens of millions of packages daily via thousands of blue delivery vans, but the drivers driving those vans are technically not Amazon employees.



The Evidence,
Amazon created the Delivery Service Partner (DSP) program. small, independent businesses contracted to manage 20–40 drivers.

Amazon monitors the drivers using AI cameras, dictates their precise routes, specifies their uniforms, enforces performance quotas, and controls their pay rates through contract pricing.

However, when drivers get into severe accidents due to exhaustion, or are denied overtime and bathroom breaks, Amazon's legal team argues in court that the driver is an employee of the DSP LLC, not Amazon.

The Reality,
A state antitrust and labor lawsuit filed by New Jersey formally alleged that Amazon deliberately uses DSPs to extract maximum work while maintaining legal immunity from labor standards, unionization rights, and liability for worker injury.

Learn More Here: Amazon accused of 'grueling working conditions' and wage suppression in groundbreaking N.J. lawsuit

Supply Chain Insulation & Human Costs

Modern Supply Chain Litigation (Child & Forced Labor Cases)

The Case,
In deep supply chains for raw materials like cobalt (used in electric vehicles and smartphones), global tech giants rely on third-party aggregators.

Humanium
Let's make children's rights a reality worldwide
Children's Rights Situation in Countries Topics Articles

The current state of child labour in cobalt mines in the Democratic Republic of the Congo



The Evidence,
Human rights organizations (such as International Rights Advocates) filed federal lawsuits documenting severe human exploitation in Democratic Republic of Congo mines, including child labor and unsafe hand-digging conditions—providing materials to tech conglomerates.

Mega-corporations repeatedly obtain dismissals or defense rulings in U.S. federal courts by showing their supplier code of conduct contracts and asserting that third-party refiners or local brokers breached terms, placing the legal blame on overseas entities.

The Reality,
The system allows top-tier corporations to access cheap raw materials to achieve multi-trillion-dollar valuations while ensuring the actual human cost remains contractually separate from executive liability."

Learn More Here: The current state of child labour in cobalt mines in the Democratic Republic of the Congo - Humanium
Now, one pattern here to take note of is that, In all of these cases:

1. *The profit flows directly upward to executives and shareholders.*
2. *The debt, risk, legal liability, or physical harm is pushed downward onto employees, subcontractors, or taxpayers.*
3. *It is done inside established legal structures, requiring no secret criminal enterprise, just high-priced legal and financial engineering.*

CHAPTER – 4
DEVOURING & FEASTING HUMAN BLOOD

As if that is not enough, they literally feast on Human blood. When immense corporate power is insulated by money and legal shielding, basic ethical boundaries erode. There are huge set of methods that these multi-billionaires adapt to engage in such inhumane practices.

We need to think about the people that die by the hands of these ruthless hyper-wealthy individuals, think about their children, even potentially their babies. Think of their old parents, they might were only in their homes who could earn. A whole family gets devastated just because of their inhumane actions. Think actually they were too humans, they had dreams, they had future plans, they had names. For these billionaires, these all just doesn't mean anything until it is not about them, for them those dreams, future plans, happiness, sorrow mean nothing but several pennies.

Let me mention below, some of these inhumane practices that they follow.

Treating Human Health and Safety as a Balance-Sheet Variable

When managing billion-dollar operations, executives often calculate the cost of human lives against the cost of safety fixes, choosing profits over human survival.

1. ***The Ford Pinto "Cost-Benefit" Formula***
   During the 1970s, internal Ford Motor Company documents (the infamous Pinto Memo) revealed that corporate executives calculated it would cost $11 per car to fix a defective fuel tank design that exploded in rear-end collisions.

   The executives assigned a monetary value to human life ($200,000 per burn victim's death) and mathematically determined that paying out death settlements was cheaper than spending $137 million to recall and fix the cars.



Learn More Here: The Pinto Memo: 'It's Cheaper to let them Burn!'

2. ***The Boeing 737 MAX Crisis (2018–2019)***
   Corporate leadership rushed the 737 MAX into production to compete with Airbus. Decisions were made to hide critical flight control software (MCAS) details from pilots to avoid expensive simulator training requirements, resulting in two catastrophic crashes that killed 346 people.



Learn More Here: [Boeing 737 Max: What's Happened After the 2 Deadly Crashes - The New York Times]

Knowingly Poisoning Communities for Profit

When industrial executives face environmental contamination choices, they suppress internal scientific findings to protect short-term earnings.

1. ***DuPont & C8 (PFAS "Forever Chemicals"),***
   For decades, DuPont executives used C8 (a chemical component of Teflon) in manufacturing, despite internal research confirming it caused cancer, birth defects, and organ damage in humans. DuPont continued dumping millions of pounds of toxic waste into Ohio River water supplies while covering up internal medical studies. The saga directly inspired the documentary record of industrial negligence.



Learn More Here: [Companies Hid Dangers of PFAS Forever Chemicals For Decades]

2. ***Purdue Pharma & The Sackler Family,***
   Executives at Purdue Pharma aggressively marketed and promoted OxyContin completely knowing about its addictive danger. Internal emails showed family executives pushing sales teams to target high-prescribing doctors and reframing victims of addiction as "reckless criminals" to protect their family's multi-billion-dollar fortune.

Exploiting Vulnerable Labor in Conflict Zones

Global conglomerates frequently leverage local armed groups or turn a blind eye to physical violence when extracting raw materials from weak countries, to keep costs low.

1. ***The Chiquita Brands International Paramilitary Payments,***
   In federal court investigations Chiquita admitted to making regular protection payments to the Autodefensas Unidas de Colombia (AUC) which is a recognized terrorist paramilitary group responsible for massacres and extrajudicial killings. Chiquita paid them to maintain security over banana plantations, prioritize labor control, and prevent union formation.

2. ***Cobalt & Mining Exploitation in the DRC,***
   Multi-national tech executives source raw battery materials through local brokers that rely on unsafe artisanal mining operations where children dig in collapsed hand-mined shafts without protective gear. Corporate headquarters maintain strict supplier standards on paper while profiting off raw materials extracted in deadly conditions.

Weaponizing NDAs and Surveillance to Destroy Whistleblowers

non-disclosure agreements (NDAs), private security teams, and legal intimidation is used by executives who commit systemic misdeeds to destroy the lives of anyone who speaks out.

1. ***Theranos & Black Cube:***
   When whistleblowers (like Erika Cheung and Tyler Shultz) attempted to report that Elizabeth Holmes' medical testing devices did not work and were putting real patients at risk, Theranos leadership hired high-priced legal firms and private investigators (even worst including ex-intelligence officers) to tail them, harass their families, and threaten them with total financial ruin through legal fees.



2. ***Corporate Surveillance of Union Organizers:*** *Leaked internal documents from major retail and tech conglomerates have repeatedly shown executives authorizing specialized intelligence units to monitor internal worker forums, track organizers, and actively disrupt union drives.*

Weaponizing Philanthropic "Reputation Laundering"

Philanthropic Counter-Branding is a common tactic used by ultra-wealthy figures to shield their behaviors from public critique.

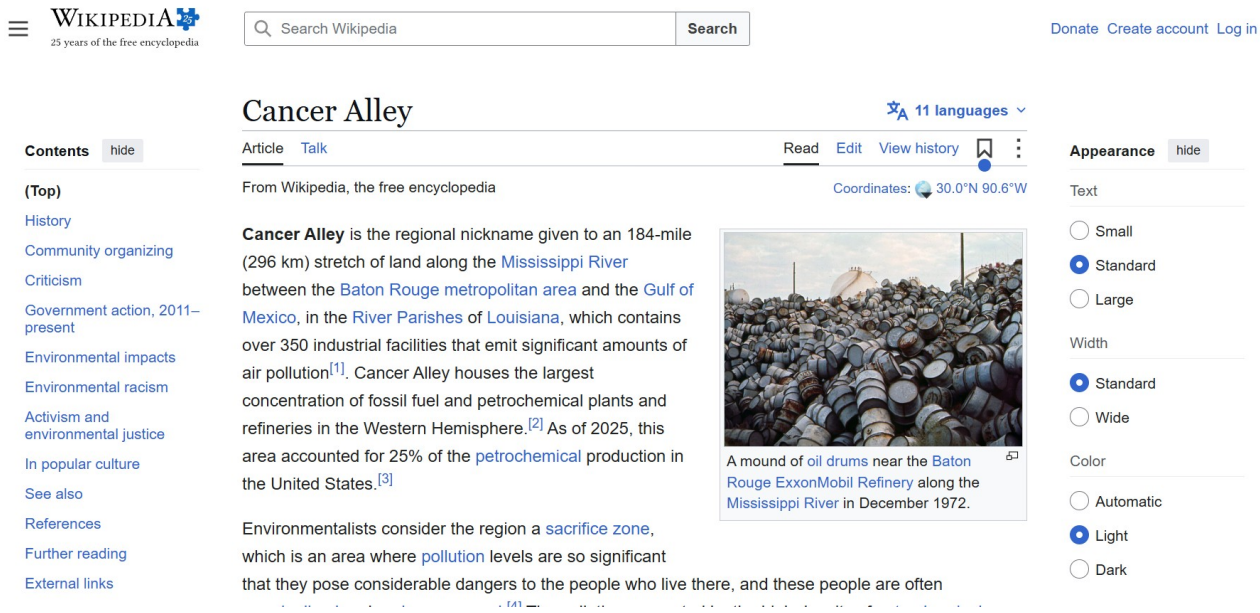
The Playbook,
An executive extracts billions through aggressive market tactics, environmental damage, or labor suppression. They then allocate a small percentage (for example, 2–5%) of their net worth to high-visibility public causes, such as funding university wings, museum halls, or global foundations.

The Reality,
The tax-deductible charitable giving earns them public honors and positive press coverage, effectively neutralizing investigative reporting into their business practices.

Mass Environmental "Sacrifice Zones"

These hyper-wealthy executives often decide to build or operate hazardous chemical and manufacturing infrastructure exclusively in low-income or racial-minority neighborhoods, treating those populations as acceptable collateral.

"Cancer Alley" in Louisiana (Formosa Plastics & Chemical Executives),
Executives have built dense corridors of petrochemical plants along the Mississippi River in predominantly Black (racial-minority), low-income communities.



The Human Cost,
Air pollution levels in these areas carry some of the highest lifetime cancer risks in the developed world. When local residents protest over toxic air emissions, corporate legal teams

deploy lobbying strategies and local land-use laws to ensure operations continue without any air-filtration upgrades.

Learn More Here: Cancer Alley - Wikipedia

Weaponizing Medical Patents to Deny Lifesaving Treatments

In global health, pharmaceutical executives regularly protect regional pricing structures even when doing so results in mass preventable deaths in lower-income nations.

The South African HIV/AIDS Drug Lawsuit (1998–2001),
During the peak of the HIV pandemic in Africa, 39 global pharmaceutical conglomerates sued the South African government under Nelson Mandela to remove a law that permitted the import of affordable, generic versions of life-saving antiretroviral drugs.


i-base Search Menu

Drug companies withdraw HIV drug lawsuit against South Africa

17 May 2001. Related: Treatment access.

The Pharmaceutical Manufacturers Association of South Africa and 39 pharmaceutical companies today agreed to drop their lawsuit against the South African government over a law that would allow the country to import and manufacture cheaper generic HIV drugs, the South African Broadcasting Corporation reports (South African Broadcasting Corporation, 19/4).

The BBC News reports that AIDS activists cheered when the announcement was made after a hearing that "lasted less than a minute" (BBC News, 19/4).

In an "unconditional surrender," the drug companies agreed to accept "virtually all of the legislation," but are urging the government to rewrite a "key section" of the law "to clarify and limit the circumstances in which it can grant compulsory licenses for third parties to manufacture patented medicines at a

The Reality: *While millions of citizens were dying because they could not afford the $10,000/year branded drug prices set by Western executives, the companies fought to enforce patent rights, prioritizing international pricing power over basic human survival. (Thankfully, the lawsuits were eventually dropped due to massive global public outrage).*

Learn More Here: Drug companies withdraw HIV drug lawsuit against South Africa | HIV i-Base

Forced Labor Subcontracting & Human Trafficking Immunity

Multinational agricultural and manufacturing conglomerates frequently structure their supply chains to use forced labor while maintaining legal denial.

Palm Oil Plantations in Southeast Asia,
Investigations by major media outlets (including the Associated Press) documented systemic human trafficking, child labor, and physical abuse on palm oil plantations supplying major global food, consumer goods, and cosmetics corporations.

The Executive Shield,
By purchasing raw materials from independent suppliers rather than owning the plantations directly, executives maintain total legal immunity from the human rights abuses occurring at the bottom of the chain.

In essence, these all demonstrate that when extreme wealth becomes the ultimate measure of success, human beings are routinely reduced to disposable operational inputs. The ruthlessness is not just a personal trait, it is a strategy designed to maximize extraction at any cost.

EVIDENCES & REAL-LIFE CASES

Again, we cannot claim all of this just based on our opinions, now it would be much clear that none can ever make billions just by hard work or whatever, its almost impossible for a system or individual to make that much. Below are some evidences and real-life cases that supports the above claims.

“
Bhopal Gas Disaster & Warren Anderson (Union Carbide)

The Incident,
In December 1984, the Union Carbide pesticide plant in Bhopal, India, leaked over 40 tons of highly toxic methyl isocyanate gas into surrounding poor slum communities.

The Human Impact,
Over 3,800 people died immediately, and an estimated 15,000 to 20,000 died in the aftermath, with over 500,000 residents suffering severe permanent injuries, blindness, and birth defects.



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Bhopal disaster

64 languages

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- Additional Union Carbide actions
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This article cites its sources **but does not provide page references**. Please help improve it by providing page numbers for existing citations. *(December 2020)* *(Learn how and when to remove this message)*

On 3 December 1984, over 500,000 people in the vicinity of the Union Carbide India Limited pesticide plant in Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh, India, were exposed to the highly toxic gas methyl isocyanate, in what is considered the world's worst industrial disaster, as well as the largest chemical disaster in Indian history.[3] A government affidavit in 2006 stated that the leak caused approximately 558,125 injuries, including 38,478 temporary partial injuries and 3,900 severely and permanently disabling injuries.[4] Estimates vary on the

Bhopal disaster

The Bhopal pesticide plant of Union Carbide India Limited in 1985, a year after the disaster

Appearance hide

Text
- Small
- Standard
- Large

Width
- Standard
- Wide

Color
- Automatic
- Light
- Dark



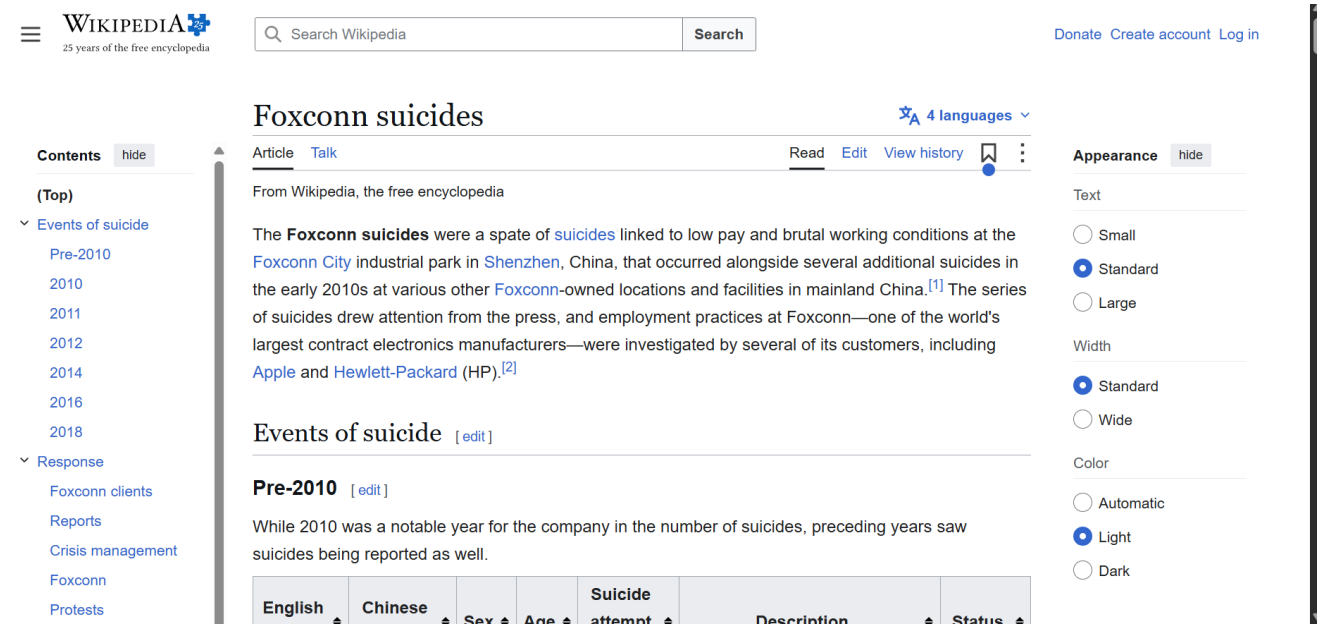
Executive Behavior,
Under CEO Warren Anderson, Union Carbide had systematically deferred safety maintenance, laid off qualified technicians, and turned off safety cooling systems to cut operating costs at the Indian subsidiary. When Indian authorities arrested Anderson upon his arrival in India, he posted bail, fled back to the U.S., and spent the rest of his life as an international fugitive, shielded from extradition by U.S. corporate and legal protection.

Learn More Here: Bhopal disaster - Wikipedia

The Foxconn Suicide Wave & Supply Chain Demand (Apple, HP & Tech Supply Chains)

The Incident,
Between 2010 and 2012, a wave of factory workers committed suicide by jumping off assembly plant buildings at Foxconn facilities in Shenzhen, China, where iPhones and consumer electronics were manufactured.

The Human Impact,
Young migrant workers, working up to 14-hour shifts under brutal quota pressure, strict enforcement silence, and verbal abuse by managers, chose to end their lives.



Executive Behavior,
Rather than restructuring production deadlines or raising worker safety and psychological standards, corporate leadership responded by installing anti-suicide nets around the dormitories to catch falling bodies, allowing factory operations to continue uninterrupted.

Learn More Here: Foxconn suicides - Wikipedia

Trafigura Toxic Waste Dumping in Côte d'Ivoire (2006)

The Incident,
Trafigura, a multi-billion-dollar multinational commodities trading corporation, sought to dispose of toxic chemical waste from oil refining. To avoid paying high disposal fees in Europe ($300,000+), executives hired a local contractor in Abidjan, Côte d'Ivoire, for just $18,000.

The Human Impact,
The toxic waste was dumped at 12 open-air city landfills near poor residential neighborhoods. Over 100,000 people sought medical care for chemical burns, severe respiratory distress, and nausea, resulting in at least 15 deaths.

Executive Behavior,
When whistleblowers and journalists exposed internal emails showing Trafigura executives knew the waste was highly toxic, Trafigura hired high-priced London legal teams to secure super-injunctions

(gag orders preventing the media from even reporting the existence of the lawsuit), attempting to publicly discredit and silence affected victims.

Chevron and the Destruction of Indigenous Amazon Communities (Lago Agrio Case)

The Incident,
For decades, Texaco (later acquired by Chevron) dumped over 16 billion gallons of toxic oil wastewater directly into local streams and rivers in the Ecuadorian Amazon, relied upon by indigenous local populations for drinking and farming.

The Human Impact,
Indigenous communities experienced rampant rates of cancer, birth defects, and complete destruction of their ancestral lands.

Executive Behavior,
When an Ecuadorian court ordered Chevron to pay an $8.6 billion environmental judgment, Chevron pulled all its assets out of Ecuador. It then spent tens of millions of dollars deploying private investigators and legal countersuits against Steven Donziger, the human rights lawyer representing the indigenous farmers. Donziger was subjected to home confinement for over 900 days in an unprecedented private prosecution, while the affected indigenous communities received zero cleanup funds."

CHAPTER – 5
PSYCHOLOGICAL EXPLOITATION

As if that all wasn't enough, they also take advantage of loopholes in human natural behaviors. They exploit those loopholes to their benefit, damaging humans emotionally and mentally. Potentially worsening/altering the behavior, attitude, ethics of youth. In other words, they are directly or indirectly involved in making our newer generations mentally handicapped and potentially degrading the morals and values of our society. They are potentially distorting the thinking capability of newer generations which actually directly affects their actions, actually leading them to the prisons, trauma, stress, depression and at the end suicides. Another region of concern is that due to this exploitation, our youngsters potentially loses their capability to think, they literally cannot think neither they have any creativity left, they become nothing more than a sloth. They literally just becomes mentally blank and stays in their comfort zone, more likely in their beds.

Algorithmic Addiction & Exploitation of Youth Mental Health

Here, executive suites at major social platforms have historically prioritized engagement metrics over child safety, knowing their decisions directly contribute to severe harm.

> ***The Facebook/Instagram Whistleblower Leaks (Frances Haugen, 2021),***
> *Actually internal research conducted by Meta revealed that executives were fully aware Instagram made body image issues worse for 1 in 3 teenage girls and increased rates of anxiety, depression, and suicide.*





The Executive Decision,
Despite internal recommendations to alter recommendation algorithms to protect minors, executive leadership repeatedly chose to optimize for platform retention and ad impressions, prioritizing screen time and profit over child safety. Learn More Here: 2021 Facebook leak - Wikipedia

Dehumanizing Workers Through Total Digital Surveillance

Modern logistics and service multi-billionaires have shifted from treating workers like human employees to managing them strictly like machine parts.

1. ***Automated Termination & Rate Metrics,***
   At major e-commerce fulfillment operations, human managers are often replaced by algorithmic tracking. If an employee's hand-scanner indicates "Time Off Task" exceeding a few minutes (even for restroom breaks or heat exhaustion recovery), algorithms generate automated warnings and firing notices.



2. ***The Impact,***
   Workers are forced to sacrifice basic physical dignity, such as carrying personal bottles to avoid taking bathroom breaks, to avoid automated termination systems designed to extract maximum speed.

Learn More Here: amazon_worker_report_10_15.pdf

While standard small business owners exploit simple cognitive biases, like price anchoring ($99.99 instead of $100) or scarcity marketing ("Only 2 items left!"), multi-billionaires operate at a completely different scale. They exploit deep, hardwired human neurological vulnerabilities, and evolutionary survival instincts.

Intermittent Variable Rewards (Dopamine Loop Engineering)

Small businesses offer fixed rewards (you pay $5, you get a coffee). Tech billionaires build systems based on variable rewards, this is the exact mechanism that makes slot machines and gambling addictive.

Trigger (Notification / Cue) leads to Action (Open App / Scroll) and you get Variable Reward (Like, Message, News, or Nothing) resulting in Investment (Post, Comment, Data)

The Psychology,
The human brain releases maximum dopamine during the anticipation of an unpredictable reward, not when it simply gets a reward.

The Exploitation,
Social media platforms (TikTok, Meta, X) do not show you the best content all at once. They mix boring posts with unexpected viral hits or social validation (likes). This unpredictability keeps your brain in a perpetual state of searching, keeping daily active user (DAU) metrics high enough to justify multi-billion-dollar valuations.

Artificial Identity & In-Group Status Anxiety (The Luxury/Ecosystem Trap)

Normal businesses sell product ("This jacket keeps you warm"). Billionaire-led enterprises sell identity confirmation and social survival.

The Psychology,
Evolutionarily, being expelled from the tribe meant death. Humans naturally crave for signatures of high status and "in-group" belonging.

“
Apple's "Green Bubble vs. Blue Bubble",
By intentionally degrading text functionality between iPhones and Androids, Apple creates social friction for teenagers and young adults. The fear of being the social outcast holding the "green bubble" drives millions of consumers to buy $1,200 phones they often cannot afford.”

Tesla & Luxury Status,
Positioning a vehicle not as just transportation, but as an identity of future-forward intelligence.

Asymmetric Information & Cognitive Friction Minimization ("Default Bias")

Billion-dollar platforms design systems where doing what they want requires zero thought, while opting out requires extreme mental effort.

The Psychology,
The brain consumes almost 20% of body's energy. To save energy, humans default to the path of least mental stress that we call as Default Bias.

Dark Patterns in Subscriptions,
One-click sign-ups paired with multi-step, cancellation processes (requiring phone calls, filling out forms, or navigating hidden menus).

Auto-Play Algorithms,
YouTube and Netflix removed the decision-making step completely. They hijack your default inertia by playing the next video automatically within 5 seconds, turning a 20-minute watch session into 3 hours of ad exposure.

Manufactured FOMO & Network Lock-In (The Metcalfe Effect)

Billionaires uses the psychological pain of Loss Aversion, which is the psychological reality that humans feel the pain of losing something twice as intensely as the pleasure of gaining it.

Single User Joins Platform and Deposits Social Capital (Photos, Followers, History) eventually Switching Costs Become Too High resulting in Trapped User.

The Psychology,
Once a person gives time, effort, and social connections into a platform, leaving feels like abandoning a massive portion of their identity and social life (Called as Sunk Cost Fallacy).

The Exploitation,
Platforms actively encourage you to build your entire social graph on their site (LinkedIn, Instagram). Once your entire network is there, the cost of leaving is potential isolation, not just closing an account. You stay on the platform even if you hate its policies, UI, or leadership.

The "IKEA Effect" & Co-Creation Illusion

Normally businesses give you a finished product. Ultra-successful digital platforms make you build the product for them, which ironically makes you love it more.

The Psychology,
When people put their own effort into creating something, they value it disproportionately higher than if it were given to them ready-made, it is referred to as The IKEA Effect.

User-Generated Content (UGC),
Platforms like YouTube, TikTok, and Reddit pay virtually $0 for the majority of their main product which is the content. Millions of users work hundreds of hours creating content for free, driven by the desire for status, and then feel deeply attached to the platform because they built their profile themselves.

Social Proof Cascades & Manufactured Consensus

Normal businesses ask for reviews. Billionaires uses Informational Social Cascade Theory to trigger herd behavior on a large scale.

The Psychology,
Under uncertainty, human beings stop relying on their own logic and instead mimic the actions of the majority which is known as Pluralistic Ignorance. If everyone in a group acts as if something is valuable or safe, an individual's brain automatically overrides its own skepticism.

The Pitching Strategy,
Founders never say "Here is our product" when pitching investors, They say "Sequoia, Andreessen Horowitz, and Benchmark are competing for this allocation." Investors rush to join the round not because they thoroughly audited the technology, but because everyone else is rushing in.

Viral Engine Design,
Uber, Paypal, and Dropbox didn't just market products, they built explicit referral loops ("Give $10, Get $10") that forced users to recruit their friends. When 5 of your friends use a platform, your brain perceive it as an industry standard rather than a choice.

Dopamine-Driven "Prediction Error" (The Infinite Scroll & Content Feeds)

While small businesses offer static experiences (a menu, a catalog), tech giants tap directly into the brain's Reward Prediction Error (RPE) mechanics.

Expected Outcome (Moderate Content) with periodic Actual Outcome (Mind-Blowing Viral Video) leading to High RPE resulting in Mass Dopamine Surge making you Craving Next Scroll.

The Psychology,
Your brain releases a surge of dopamine when an outcome is better than expected. If every video was amazing, your brain would adapt and get bored.

The Exploitation,
Algorithms deliberately serve you 3–4 mediocre or irrelevant items followed by 1 hyper-targeted, highly emotional piece of content. This variance keeps your brain's prediction error system constantly triggering, creating an addictive scrolling loop that hijacks your attention for hours.

The Hooked Protocol & Habit-Loop Rewiring

Small businesses try to persuade you to make a decision to buy. Billionaires build systems that bypass conscious thought, converting actions into unconscious habits.

The Psychology,
Habit forms when a sequence of actions becomes automated in the basal ganglia, requiring zero conscious decision-making or willpower.

The Exploitation,
Nir Eyal's Hook Model (used explicitly by companies like Instagram, Slack, and Duolingo) attaches digital actions to negative internal triggers:

- ***Boredom*** *→ Open Instagram.*
- ***Anxiety / Fear of Missing Out*** *→ Open X or news apps.*
- ***Work Stress / Loneliness*** *→ Open Slack or Discord.*
- *Over time, you no longer decide to open these apps, your brain does this automatically to relieve mild emotional discomfort.*

Hyperbolic Discounting & Frictionless Capital Extraction

Traditional businesses rely on immediate exchanges ($20 cash for a shirt). Multi-billion-dollar models exploit Hyperbolic Discounting, the neurological tendency to overvalue immediate rewards while drastically discounting future costs.

The Psychology,
The human brain evolved in environments of scarcity, so it prioritizes present gratification over future consequences. Furthermore, physical money activates pain centers in the brain, whereas digital/abstract transactions suppress that pain response.

Buy Now, Pay Later (Klarna, Affirm),
Disconnects the pleasure of acquiring a product from the pain of paying for it, causing consumers to spend 20–40% more per transaction.

One-Click & In-App Currency,
Replacing real money with abstract tokens (e.g., game gems, V-Bucks, or auto-renewing subscriptions) disguises the economic reality, leading to frictionless spending.

REAL LIFE CASES

Now let me quote some real-life cases, since we cannot just claim based on our opinions.

“

TikTok's "For You" Page (ByteDance / Zhang Yiming)

How It Played Out,
TikTok transformed algorithmic feeds by eliminating fixed rewards or chronologically ordered feeds. When you pull down to refresh or swipe up, the algorithm intentionally serves you a mix of uninteresting clips interspersed with unexpected viral hits, highly relatable humor, or shocking news.

The Result,
The neurological unpredictability creates a classic slot-machine dopamine loop. TikTok users spend an average of over 95 minutes per day on the app, making ByteDance one of the most valuable private tech monopolies in history ($200B+ valuation).

Apple's "Green Bubble vs. Blue Bubble" (Steve Jobs & Tim Cook)

How It Played Out,
When sending text messages between iPhones, messages appear as blue bubbles with full iMessage features (read receipts, high-res photos, typing indicators). When texting an Android user, Apple degrades the experience to legacy SMS, turning the bubble green, compressing images into low resolution, and breaking group chats. Internal Apple emails revealed that executives explicitly rejected making iMessage available on Android to keep users locked in.

The Result,
This engineered social friction created real-world status anxiety, particularly among teens and college students, where green-bubble users face social exclusion. It helped Apple capture over 85% of the U.S. teen smartphone market.

Amazon Prime Cancellation Dark Patterns (Jeff Bezos)

How It Played Out,
Signing up for Amazon Prime takes one single click. However, for years Amazon used a dark-pattern design internally codenamed "Iliad" to prevent users from cancelling. Users attempting to cancel were forced to navigate a multi-page maze of warnings, redirect buttons, hidden links, and confusingly phrased confirmation prompts ("Keep My Benefits" vs. "Continue to Cancel").

The Result,
By creating extreme cognitive friction for cancellation while leaving sign-up completely frictionless, Amazon retained millions of subscribers who intended to cancel, driving billions in recurring revenue until federal regulators intervened.

Facebook's Early Expansion (Mark Zuckerberg)

How It Played Out,
In its early days, Facebook expanded strictly campus-by-campus (Harvard first, then Ivy League, then all universities). By making access exclusive to specific email domains, Zuckerberg created intense FOMO among excluded students. Once a critical mass at a university joined, non-users realized their entire campus social life (events, study groups, photo sharing) had moved to Facebook.

The Result,
Leaving the platform meant complete social isolation which is Sunk Cost of Social Capital. This network density propelled Facebook past Myspace, building a network of over 3 billion active monthly users across Meta apps.

YouTube Creators & Communities (Neal Mohan / Susan Wojcicki / Alphabet)

How It Played Out,
Unlike traditional TV networks (HBO, Netflix) that spend billions creating professional content, YouTube built a framework where users supply 100% of the content. Millions of creators spend hundreds of unpaid hours editing videos, designing thumbnails, and building subscriber channels.

The Result,
Because creators invest their own labor into building their channels, they experience intense psychological ownership over the platform. Even when YouTube cuts ad payouts or changes algorithm rules, creators rarely leave because their identity, audience, and effort are tied directly to their YouTube account.

WeWork & SoftBank Valuation Inflation (Adam Neumann / Masayoshi Son)

How It Played Out,
Adam Neumann did not sell WeWork as a standard office subleasing business. He engineered a narrative that WeWork was a revolutionary tech-and-consciousness movement. When SoftBank's Vision Fund injected billions into WeWork at staggering valuations (reaching $47 Billion), other institutional investors and private banks stampeded to participate.

The Result,
Wall Street banks and VCs abandoned standard due-diligence audit procedures because everyone else was bidding up the valuation. The herd behavior held the multi-billion-dollar illusion together until public S-1 filing metrics exposed massive structural losses.

Tinder's Swipe Mechanics (Match Group / Sean Rad)

How It Played Out,
Tinder redesigned dating apps around the physical swipe motion. Swiping right doesn't guarantee a match; most swipes yield nothing, but occasionally a match pops up with bright visual feedback.

The Result,
The app leverages Reward Prediction Error. The anticipation of whether the next swipe will deliver a match (an outcome better than expected) triggers a sudden surge of dopamine. Match Group monetized

this by limiting daily swipes and charging premium subscriptions (Tinder Gold/Platinum) for users desperate to uncover matches faster.

Slack & Corporate Communication Lock-In (Stewart Butterfield)

How It Played Out,
Slack deliberately engineered its notification badges (the red dot, the distinct knock-brush chime) to attach to internal work stress and fear of missing an urgent task.

The Result,
Employees quickly form an automatic sub-conscious habit: feel a spike of workplace anxiety → check Slack. Over time, checking Slack becomes an automated routine executed hundreds of times per day. Corporate teams become so neurologically hooked on Slack's instant loop that switching to another tool causes massive internal friction, allowing Salesforce to acquire Slack for $27.7 Billion.

Epic Games' Fortnite V-Bucks Economy (Tim Sweeney)

How It Played Out,
Epic Games removed the direct exchange of real currency for items inside Fortnite. Players cannot buy a $10 skin directly; they must first buy an abstract digital currency called V-Bucks in preset bundles (e.g., 1,000 V-Bucks for $8.99).

The Result,

1. ***Decoupling Pain from Spending,***

Converting real money into in-game points suppresses the brain's pain response associated with spending cash.

2. ***Uneven Pricing Math:*** *Skins are intentionally priced at awkward amounts (e.g., 1,200 V-Bucks), forcing players to buy larger bundles and leaving unused points sitting in their accounts, which triggers the Sunk Cost Fallacy to buy more V-Bucks to use up the remainder. This system turned a free-to-play game into an engine generating billions annually.**"***

CHAPTER – 6
PSYCHOLOGY OF THE DEVIL

Now, you must be thinking why do they do it? Why do they do these all inhumane practices? Well, we have already discussed some of the reasons, but that weren't all of them. This one is specifically dedicated to what actually their psychology is? How do they think, why do they think that way? If you have similar questions in your head, here are the reasons.

Hubris Syndrome (The "God Complex")

Researchers studying powerful political and business leaders states, Hubris Syndrome is a personality shift that happens precisely because of extreme power and success.

The Trait,
They develop an exaggerated, irrational self-belief almost reaching omnipotence. They genuinely stop viewing themselves as regular mortals subject to rules, laws, or social norms.



In Practice,
They believe their judgment is infallible. If a normal person makes a mistake, they feel shame. But hilariously, a billionaire views failure merely as proof that reality or other people were simply too small-minded to understand their "genius vision", how ridiculous is that.

Learn More Here: Why Modern Executives Are More Susceptible to Hubris Than Ever

Pathological Risk-Insensitivity (Fear Blindness)

Ordinary human beings possess a sense of fear, caution, and anxiety regarding risk because failure threatens their survival, housing, or family security.

The Trait,
Ultra-wealthy individuals often exhibit a blunted response to risk and danger. Because their baseline wealth is so huge that they could fail ten times over and still live like royalty, the sensation of "fear" or "financial anxiety" is entirely foreign to them.

In Practice,
This allows them to gamble with thousands of other people's jobs, lifelong savings, or community stability with complete emotional coldness. What feels like a high-stakes human tragedy to workers is treated by the executive as a casual, risk-free adventure.

Radical Empathy Erosion (Dehumanization as a Default State)

Neuroscientific studies on power show that holding absolute authority physically alters how the human brain perceives other people.

The Trait,
The part of the brain responsible for empathy (the mirror neuron system as discussed earlier) literally fires less when looking at or thinking about people below you.

In Practice,
They don’t just choose to be cruel, they literally lose the neurological ability to viscerally feel another person's pain. When they lay off 5,000 workers via an automated email, they don't picture families struggling to buy groceries, they only look at a line item on a spreadsheet labeled "headcount optimization."

Machiavellian Deception & Shifting Liability
As we discussed earlier, self-preservation at the top requires an elite level of tactical manipulation.

The Trait,
Viewing human relationships purely as transactional chess pieces. Every single person, from a government regulatory officer to a childhood friend, everyone is evaluated strictly by what utility they provide.

In Practice,
They literally become the kings of moral outsourcing. They can smile publicly about philanthropy while at the same time signing off on policies that pollute a river or crush a union. They separate their public

persona (the "visionary philanthropist") from their actual reality (the ruthless extractor) without feeling any internal contradiction or hypocrisy.

Severe Reality Isolation (The "Bubble" Effect)

The Trait,
Billionaires are rarely told "no" by anyone in their circle. In other words, extreme wealth creates a physical and social vacuum.

In Practice,
They live in private jets, gated compounds, and secure fortresses surrounded by high-paid handlers, public relations teams, and sycophants whose livelihood depends on keeping the billionaire happy. With the passage of time, they lose connection with baseline human experiences, like standing in line, paying utility bills, or facing a medical debt crisis, making them entirely unable to understand ordinary human realities.

Grandiose Narcissism & "Reality Distortion Fields"

The Trait,
Narcissism combined with unlimited capital creates a phenomenon where executives believe their personal desires changes reality, even physical laws, or regulatory facts. Anyone who claims that something is impossible, illegal, or dangerous is never viewed as a helpful advisor, but as a "hater" or enemy who must be crushed.

Documented Real-World Case – Elizabeth Holmes and Theranos,
Holmes made nearly $1 billion by claiming her blood-testing device could perform hundreds of tests from a single drop of finger-pricked blood. When internal scientists and lab directors proved mathematically and physically that the technology is useless, Holmes did not fixed that. Instead, she fired them, threatened them with multi-million dollar lawsuits, and used private security teams (Black Cube) to intimidate whistleblowers.

- ***The Reality,***

She lived in a self-constructed reality distortion field, convincing herself that her "vision" justified committing massive fraud against patients, doctors, and investors alike until federal enforcement forced her into a prison cell.

Authoritarian Intolerance of Dissent & Public Retaliation

The Trait,
Multi-billionaires often posture publicly as champions of free speech or disruption, their internal management style is frequently dictatorial. They demand absolute loyalty, view independent thought as insubordination, and use their vast wealth or platform reach to publicly humiliate or ruin critics.

Documented Real-World Case – Elon Musk's Management of X and Internal Dissent,
After acquisition of Twitter in late 2022, multiple engineers and software developers posted internal Slack messages or public tweets pointing out technical flaws in his restructuring plans or criticizing his public statements.

The Reality,
Instead of handling personnel issues through private discussions, Elon Musk publicly fired employees via X, mocked their work performance to his tens of millions of followers, and invited public pile-ons against them. This created a culture of intense fear among remaining staff, who understood that disagreeing with the billionaire meant immediate public shaming and career destruction.

Pathological Compartmentalization & Corporate Gaslighting

The Trait,
This is the psychological ability to preach high-minded ethics, or public safety while secretly directing operations that cause mass harm. Unlike ordinary liars who feel guilt internally, ultra-wealthy executives compartmentalize their minds so completely that they can fund PR campaigns masking their predatory actions without experiencing cognitive distress.

Documented Real-World Case – ExxonMobil and Decades of Climate Denial,
Internal documents dating back to the late 1970s and 1980s (uncovered by investigative journalists and academic researchers) proved that Exxon's very own top scientists accurately showed how fossil fuel and Biomass emissions would cause catastrophic global warming.

The Executive Action,
Instead of changing their business architecture, warning the public, or even spreading awareness, executive leadership launched multi-million-dollar public relations campaigns funding climate denial think tanks, casting doubt on peer-reviewed science, and lobbying against environmental regulations.

The Reality,
They protected short-term profits and multi-billion-dollar stock valuations and knowingly undermining the habitability of the planet for upcoming generations, completely insulating themselves from accountability through layered legal PR strategies.

The "Entitled Feudal Lord" Complex

The Trait,
When billionaires acquire vast acres of land, private islands, or massive corporate entities, they often regress psychologically into medieval feudal lords. They view local laws, zoning regulations, labor laws, and the rights of surrounding communities as minor annoyances to be bypassed through legal bribery, political donations, or simply intimidation.

Documented Real-World Case: The Land-Grab and "Anti-Union" Surveillance Campaigns*,*
Major tech conglomerates routinely spend millions of dollars hiring elite union-crushing law firms and private intelligence agencies. These firms deploy covert operations to monitor workers' social media accounts, infiltrate private meetings, and track union organizers.

The Reality,
When workers attempt to exercise their legal right to organize for better wages or safe working conditions, executives treat it as a personal betrayal and a threat to their absolute power, deploying huge amount of resources to crush worker solidarity before it can take root.

CHAPTER – 7
PARA-LANGUAGE OF SINS

Another key point worth mentioning is that they are liars at unimaginable scale, and while they are losing money, they confidently attempts to convince their audience to believe that they are making billions. When normal people lie, their brain triggers guilt, anxiety, and micro-expressions (sweating, eye twitching, voice tremors, avoiding eye contact). When a high-level billionaire lies, they can look at you straight in the eyes with absolute conviction.

High Narcissism and Internalizing the Lie

Normal people know they are lying when they say something untrue. Founders with high-narcissism, however, frequently engage in cognitive self-deception.

The Reality Distortion Field,
They convince themselves that their version of reality is true first. If they promise an impossible product deadline or exaggerate company measures, they genuinely believe their own hype in that moment.

Because they believe the lie themselves, their body shows zero signs of deceit. They emit pure, infectious confidence, making others fall for it.

Strategic Machiavellianism: Words as Tools, Not Truth

Language is not meant to describe reality for a person high in Machiavellian traits, it is meant to manipulate outcome.

For an average person when asked "Is this statement accurate?", Speaks truth based on morality.

A Machiavellian Founder always asks "Will saying this get me funding/market dominance?" Speaks strategically based on outcome.

To them, a "lie" isn't a moral failure, it is simply a strategic move on a chessboard. If saying something false gains them capital, power, or time, they use it without hesitation.

"Fake It Till You Make It" Escalation

In tech and venture-capital culture, overpromising is especially rewarded.

Founders are expected to sell a vision of the future that does not even exist.

A small exaggeration brings in capital and Capital hires engineers than Engineers build the product and eventually The lie turns into reality.

Because this cycle works most of the time, founders get rewarded for bold untruths. The ones who get caught early fail, but the ones who successfully pull off huge bluffs end up on magazine covers as visionary billionaires. With the passage of time, this desensitizes them, turning strategic lying into a habit.

Total Lack of Consequence and Systemic Immunity

Confidence comes from safety. Most people fear lying because they fear the consequences (getting fired, disgraced, or potentially sued). Multi-billionaires operate in an environment where they are largely insulated from immediate consequences:

Asymmetry of Power,
First, who is going to call them a liar on their face? Employees fear losing their jobs, vendors fear losing contracts, and investors fear damaging their own portfolios.

Legal Armor,
They carry armies of lawyers and PR teams that can reframe any outright lie as optimistic projection or legal misinterpretation. Behold, how hilarious is this just dropping delicious lies and alluring into investments.

Bernie Madoff (Bernard L. Madoff Investment Securities)

The Persona,
A deeply respected Wall Street veteran and former NASDAQ chairman who had steady, modest, unflappable confidence.

The Reality,
Orchestrated the largest Ponzi scheme in human history, stealing roughly $65 billion.

The Lie,
He claimed to use a complex options strategy to deliver steady, predictable returns year after year. In truth, he did no trades at all for decades; he simply took money from new investors to return old ones.

The Ruthless Behavior,
Madoff routinely stole life savings from charitable foundations, cancer funds, retirement accounts, and personal friends. He looked people in the eye at family gatherings and dinner parties, took their money, and knew it was vanishing into thin air. He felt zero remorse until the moment he was caught.

Jeffrey Skilling & Kenneth Lay (Enron)

The Persona,
Arrogant visionaries praised by business magazines as the smartest executives in corporate America.

The Reality,
Systemic, predatory deception.

The Lie,
They used illegal accounting tricks (Mark-to-Market accounting for projected future profits and off-the-books entities) to fabricate billions of dollars in fake income.

The Ruthless Behavior,
When Enron artificially created power outages in California to spike electricity prices (literally turning off power to hospitals and traffic lights so Enron traders could make money), executives were caught on tape laughing about it. As the company was crumbling, executives quietly sold off millions of dollars of their own stock while suggesting lower-level employees to keep investing their 401(k) life savings into the dying stock.

GLOSSARY

Asymmetric Information – *A dynamic where corporate executives or institutional players possess critical data, hidden legal structures, or insider foresight that everyday consumers, workers, or smaller competitors cannot access, ensuring the house always wins.*

Blitzscaling / Regulatory Arbitrage – *A hyper-growth business strategy where a company deliberately operates in violation of existing labor, safety, or commercial laws using venture capital subsidies to expand so rapidly that it becomes "too big to fail" before regulators can react.*

Buy, Borrow, Die – *A legal tax-avoidance strategy used by ultra-wealthy individuals. Instead of selling stock (which triggers capital gains tax), they borrow vast sums of cash against their shares at low interest rates, living tax-free until their assets pass down generationally.*

Dark Triad – *A psychological cluster of three interrelated personality traits, Machiavellianism (manipulativeness and viewing people as tools), Subclinical Psychopathy (lack of empathy and remorse), and Narcissism (grandiose entitlement and a belief that standard ethics do not apply to them), frequently overrepresented among corporate elites.*

Empathy Erosion (Mirror Neuron Atrophy) – *The neurological phenomenon where holding extreme power, wealth, and status physically impairs the brain's mirror neuron activity, reducing an individual's biological capacity to viscerally feel or care about the pain of others.*

Hyperbolic Discounting – *A cognitive vulnerability where the human brain heavily overvalues immediate rewards (like instant digital gratification or easy credit) while drastically discounting future consequences (like debt, addiction, or health decline).*

Leveraged Buyout (LBO) / Strip-Mining – *A corporate acquisition where a firm uses borrowed money to buy a target company, places the resulting multi-billion-dollar debt directly onto the target company's balance sheet, extracts millions in fees, and leaves the business hollowed out and vulnerable to bankruptcy.*

Patent Thickets – *A defensive legal strategy where a corporation acquires hundreds or thousands of overlapping, minor patents around a product to trap independent inventors and small competitors in exhausting, multi-million-dollar litigation until they surrender.*

Reward Prediction Error (RPE) – *A neurochemical mechanism where dopamine surges not from predictable rewards, but from unpredictable ones (such as scrolling through intermittent viral content or slot machines), creating compulsive, addictive behavioral loops.*

Bad Apples

POWER • PEOPLE • PROFIT • THE TRUTH

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RICHER
FASTER
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This is not a book about good companies or bad companies.
It is a book about power.
And power always leaves a trail.

"Behind every great success story lies a few bad apples."



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Arbab Laiq Ahmed is a writer and researcher passionate about exploring the intersection of business, influence, human behavior, and modern society. Through thoughtful analysis and engaging storytelling, Ahmed challenges readers to look beyond headlines and question the forces shaping the world around them.

GREED
MANIPULATION
CONTROL
BILLIONS

IT'S JUST BUSINESS

REAL STORIES.
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